🗓️ Timeline & Cartoons: BASIC Cartoon Handout · ANSWER KEY

US History · Unit 1 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · how to read a political cartoon

Name: _____

Use BASIC on every political cartoon this year.

B.A.S.I.C. in your own words

1. B (Background): How does background knowledge help a person understand a political cartoon?
You need to know the events and people of the time to get the joke or point.

2. Why is it harder to understand cartoons from the 1800s than today's cartoons?
We do not know the people, events and symbols of that time as well.

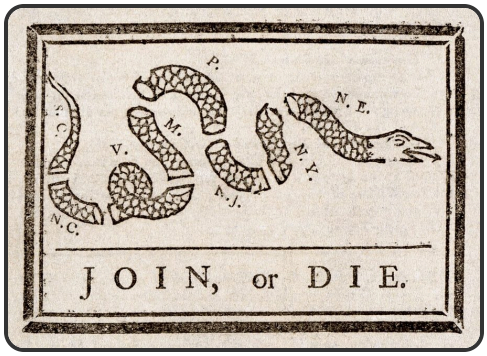
3. A (Argument): What is the goal of a political cartoon? Where in a newspaper do you find them, and why not in the comics section?
To persuade / give an opinion on an issue. On the editorial (opinion) page, because they are opinions, not just jokes.

4. S (Symbols): How are symbols used? List 3 symbols most Americans would recognize.
A picture stands for a bigger idea. Uncle Sam/eagle = USA, donkey/elephant = parties, dove = peace, $ = money.

5. I (Indicators): Where can you find indicators, and why read all of them?
Titles, labels, captions, speech bubbles. They tell who and what is shown, so you don't miss the point.

6. C (Caricature): Why is caricature used? Why are stereotypes in old cartoons a problem?
Exaggeration makes the point stronger. Stereotypes treat a whole group unfairly; many old cartoons were racist or cruel.

Practice 1: Join, or Die (1754)

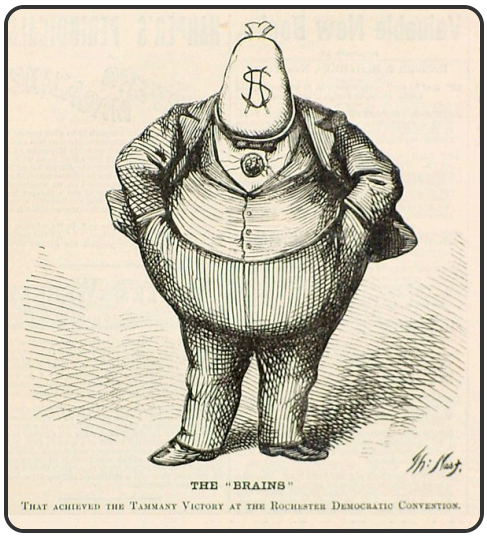


"Join, or Die." Benjamin Franklin, 1754 (public domain)

7. Fill in the table.

B	A	S	I	C
French and Indian War is starting; Franklin wants colonies to unite (Albany Plan)	**Unite or be destroyed**	**Cut-up snake = divided colonies**	**Colony initials; "JOIN, or DIE."**	**None really: the snake is a symbol, not a caricature**

Practice 2: The “Brains” (1871)



“The ‘Brains.’” Thomas Nast, 1871 (public domain). Boss Tweed ran New York City politics and stole millions.

8. Fill in the table.

B	A	S	I	C
Boss Tweed and Tammany Hall controlled NYC and stole millions	**Tweed's power comes from money and corruption**	**Moneybag for a head = his “brains” are money**	**Dollar sign; the caption about the Tammany victory**	**Huge belly and tiny head = greed**

🔑 *Key written by our team, please check.*